What Does It Mean to Build Digital Ethnic Futures? Grassroots Digital Capacity Building Through Community-Driven Practice

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This paper examines the evolution and impact of the Digital Ethnic Futures Consortium at California State University Fullerton (DEFCon), a groundbreaking grassroots capacity-building initiative for regional public universities that intersects digital humanities, ethnic studies, and future-making practices. Over the past four years, CSUF DEFCon (also known as CSUF Digital) has been one of three regional hubs in the Andrew Mellon-funded DEFCon Consortium. In this capacity, it has trained and supported over 100 faculty, students, librarians, university staff, and community partners in digital project development, data accountability, the ethical entanglements of race and technology, and community-engaged digital humanities practice both at CSUF and beyond.

Through collaborative fellowship programs, innovative workshop series, strong regional leadership, and symbiotic community partnerships, CSUF Digital has challenged traditional capacity-building models by creating grassroots communities of practice that operate from the periphery. This model centers the experiences, knowledge systems, and cultural practices of local ethnic communities, first-generation students, and faculty and scholars of color, while establishing community outside the conventional top-down endorsement models common to both CSUF and the CSU system.

By training students and faculty to collaborate with cultural organizations, CSUF Digital has increased access to digital tools across various communities while amplifying underrepresented voices, histories, and cultural practices. Community-engaged digital humanities practices—which are often public-facing—define our approach to digital ethnic studies by ensuring accountability and carefully considering whom our work serves and how it impacts them.

This paper presents preliminary findings from our recent Impact Survey, analyzing how CSUF Digital's capacity-building model has increased diversity within the field and worked in solidarity with local communities whose digital needs and practices extend beyond academic discourse. By sharing this data, we aim to provide a replicable framework for other institutions and grassroots capacity-building initiatives. We will be joined in sharing our findings with Libro Mobile Arts Cooperative and Bookstore, a key community partner. The culturally responsive methods for digital humanities training and skill-building outlined in this paper effectively prepare the next generation of social justice-engaged digital scholars, ensuring they are equipped to build digital ethnic futures both within and beyond the classroom.

Bibliography

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